

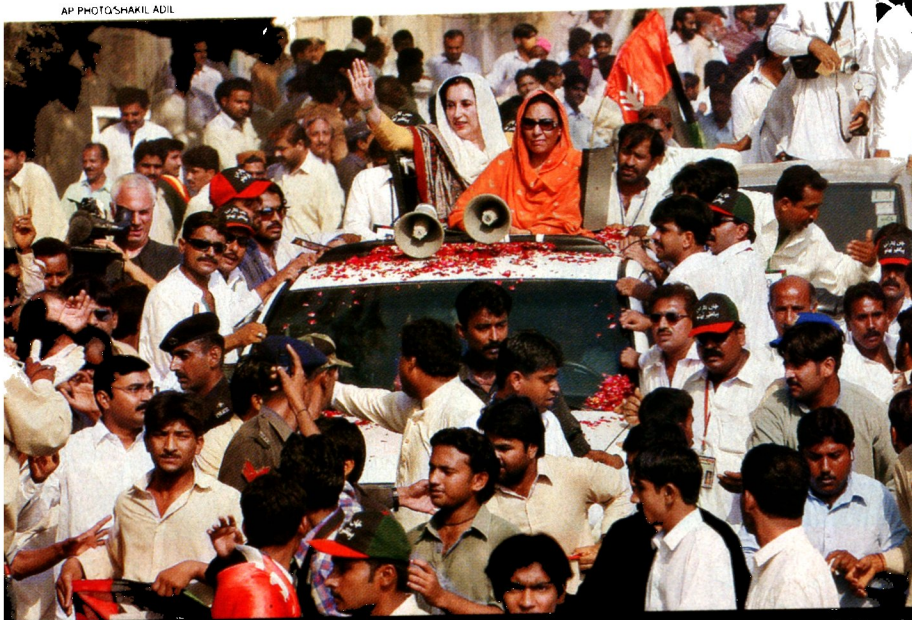
Musharraf's criticisms after speaking to US Deputy Secretary of State John Negroponte, who had flown into Islamabad "to assess the situation" and ostensibly ask the President to lift the Emergency. Having been forced to unequivocally declare—because of pressure from journalists and civil society—that she considered deposed

the unpopular President would damage her in the long term.

The establishment has also unleashed its "secret weapon", Maulana Fazlur Rahman, who heads the largest religious party—Jamiat-e-Ulema-e-Islam (JUI)—and is a member of the Nawaz Sharif-led All Parties Democratic Movement (APDM). While

having been unceremoniously bundled back into exile on his abortive return attempt on September 10, most analysts had counted him out of the equation for a few years. It now appears that the assessment was premature. But Sharif's return has probably raised more questions than it has answered. Why did Musharraf agree to allow Sharif back? Was there a deal between the two? Is Sharif the Americans' new horse? What does it mean for Benazir? Will Sharif boycott the elections?

Well placed sources say the Saudis were reluctant to continue to hold Sharif after the vitriol and embarrassment they had to face within Pakistan after the September 10 incident wherein they had overtly sided with the President. This was the first time that public sentiment had turned so openly against one of Pakistan's staunchest allies, which they considered damaging to their long-term interests. "Saudi Arabia won't be worried that they have effectively kidnapped a former prime minister of Pakistan because they run a non-



Benazir has toned down the tenor of Musharraf's criticisms and is unlikely to boycott the polls. She hopes to cash in on the disarray in Sharif's party.

chief justice Iftikhar Chaudhry as the legitimate head of the Supreme Court, Benazir has recently backtracked from this stance. Declaring that the issue of the judiciary should be left to the incoming Parliament to resolve—in effect distancing herself from the Opposition demand that the sacked judges be restored before elections—she now claims that "our fight is for the independence of the judiciary, not about individuals".

It is becoming increasingly clear that Benazir is unlikely to boycott the polls. On a campaign stop in Larkana, her home town, she disingenuously announced, "We have foiled the conspiracy of those elements within the Government who wanted us to boycott the elections". Her reduced demands of lifting of Emergency and of Musharraf stepping down as the chief of the army have been met, giving her no reason to boycott the polls. It seems obvious that she has chosen to disregard those advisers who were advocating that any compromise with

the APDM's other component parties—particularly Imran Khan's Tehrik-e-Insaaf and Qazi Hussain Ahmed's Jamaat-e-Islami (JI)—called for a boycott of the polls, Rahman threw a spanner in the works by disagreeing with the decision, claiming it was taken without consulting his party. His actions had the desired effect of splitting not just APDM but the religious party coalition, the Muttahida Majlis-e-Amal, of which JUI and JI are the main blocs.

With two opposition biggies—PPP and JUI—in the race along with the pro-Musharraf Pakistan Muslim League (PML-Q) and Muttahida Qaumi Movement (MQM), the threat of a large-scale boycott can be nullified. The only other potentially big party left, whose own decision is yet unclear, is Sharif's PML-N. By far the biggest surprise has been Sharif's return. After

representative police state themselves," wrote columnist Fasi Zaka in *The News* at that time. Pakistani governments are used to public outcries against the United States—which was also perceived to have colluded in Sharif's deportation—but not against the sensitive "brotherly Muslim countries". In fact, long before it yanked the plug on them, the Pakistan Electronic Media Regulatory Authority was constrained to issue a warning to independent television channels not to air opinion "that can damage relations with a friendly country".

The Saudis had also invested in Sharif for almost eight years and were not comfortable with

Benazir being given a free hand at the hustings at Sharif's expense. There is no doubt that given a choice, the Saudis would rather deal with a conservative Sharif than the mercurial and

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